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Pro-Russian secessionist movements had nothing to offer to the local population, as people were generally uninterested in anti-Ukrainian Russian imperial and nationalist projects. Considering the high level of paternalism among the local population, people were used to voting for the local elites and their populist parties. The majority of the pro-Russian electorate in eastern and southern Ukraine supported non-secessionist mainstream parliamentary parties that pragmatically instrumentalized pro-Russian narratives. Therefore, social conditions were insufficient for rebellions to occur without external support from Russia.

Second, as a result of such extreme fragmentation, Russia had to support rebel militias from the outset, for instance by keeping low barriers-to-entry. This can be interpreted as a necessity for Moscow to ensure the rebellion's survival by actively backing multiple militias, especially when they lacked the strength to stand against the incumbent independently. Russia arguably has intentionally kept the entry threshold into the rebellion low to encourage various militias to join. The absence of a cohesive leadership structure exacerbated tensions and undermined efforts to present a united front. Rebels heavily depended on Russian supplies, including heavy weapons and military equipment. Without this support from Moscow, their ability to sustain a prolonged conflict and face the Ukrainian forces would have been significantly compromised.

The rebels also faced challenges in garnering widespread support from the local population. This lack of broad-based local support further weakened the rebels' position. The rebels' extreme fragmentation also posed challenges to the effectiveness of Russia's support. Chaos on the ground and the lack of unified rebel structures made it difficult for Moscow to gain precise information about the various rebel proxies. The absence of a clear and united rebel command structure would indeed complicate decision-making for Moscow in terms of selecting the most suitable candidate for delegation of political and military support. This lack of cohesion led to conflicting agendas among the rebel militias, making it challenging for Russia to exert control and coordinate actions effectively.

These two central arguments are thoroughly analyzed in this book as an original and innovative perspective on understanding the conflict that started in 2014 in eastern Ukraine. The events in Ukraine in 2014 – the annexation of Crimea and the armed conflict in eastern Ukraine – shocked the world as an unprecedented act of military aggression when one sovereign state annexed the territory of another sovereign state in Europe for the first time since the Second World War. The annexation of Crimea made imperialism and nationalism key elements and driving forces of Russian foreign policy. The annexation suggested that Putin had given the Greater Russia project – annexation of the territories either settled by ethnic Russians or considered to be Russian on historical or cultural grounds – priority (Plokhly 2023).

Russia's military aggression in 2014 challenged the entire European security architecture. Russian intervention in Crimea and eastern Ukraine, using military coercion and force to take control of and destabilize the territories of a neighboring state, is a frontal challenge to the post-Cold War European regional order and a reversion to an earlier era of power politics on the European continent. Moscow judged it could take advantage of a moment of opportunity when the military and internal security forces of the Ukrainian state were fragmented, demoralized, and uncertain where their loyalties lay, having served under the Yanukovych regime that had so suddenly collapsed (Allison 2014).

Why Has Ukraine Been So Important to Russia and Putin's Regime?

Ukraine has been and probably will remain a key element in the Russian elites' thinking about their identity and destiny. This country has always occupied a special place in Russia's consciousness. Russian visions of empire, great-power status, and nationhood have all hinged on a view of Ukraine as a distinct but integral part of Russia. Russian establishment has regarded the possibility of Ukraine leaving the Russian sphere of influence as an attack on itself (Plokhly 2017, 348). It refuses to treat Ukraine as a separate nation with the right to independent statehood. Ukraine's assertion of independence delivers a crushing blow to Russia's great-power ego. Ukraine's departure from the Russian fold also poses a challenge to Russian projects for integrating neighboring countries under Moscow's leadership (Shevtsova 2020).

An independent, "Europeanized" Ukraine poses a strategic threat not so much to Russian national security as to Russian premodern, imperial identity. Ukraine's historical myths of seeking independence over a long period of time, its claim to sole historical title to the medieval principality of Kyivan Rus, and other elements of historical symbolism conflict with Russian nationalist historical and territorial claims (Riabchuk 2016). The view of Ukrainians as constituents of the Russian nation goes back to the founding myth of modern Russia as a nation conceived and born in Kyiv. Throughout most of the imperial period, Ukrainians were regarded as Little Russians – a vision that allowed for the existence of Ukrainian folk culture and spoken vernacular but not a high culture or a modern literature (Plokhly 2016, 350). Ukraine remains a crucial part of the Russian imperialistic mythology and imagination and will remain a "sublime object of desire" for too many Russians unable to reconcile themselves with its sovereignty, independent development, and integration outside Russian influence (Riabchuk 2016).

An unhealthy fixation on Ukraine demonstrates a deep post-imperial trauma in Russia. Russian political scientist Sergei Medvedev noted that "Ukrainians were too close to us, too much like us, for Russia to allow them simply to slip away quietly" (Medvedev 2020, 218–219). For a quarter of a century, Ukrainian independence was looked on as some sort of mistake, a bit of a joke – the very word *nezalezhnist'*, the Ukrainian word for "independence," was usually spoken in Russia in an ironic tone. Mykola Riabchuk adds that since Ukrainian and Russian languages are mutually comprehensible (to a degree), the purpose behind the use

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